

Session 28: The River From the Temple

Key Takeaways

- The image of a river flowing out from the mountain of God takes us right back to Eden.
- The river that flows out from the temple refreshes the most barren parts of the land, but it doesn't stop there. The ever-flowing river can be imagined as bringing God's life to the whole world.
- The name of the city is "Yahweh is over there," that is, Yahweh is in his temple, set apart from the city.

Macro Design of Ezekiel 47:1-48:35

Ezekiel 47:1-48:35

The Restored Land Inheritance as a New Eden

47:1-1

A - The River of Life from the Temple

- **47:1-5** Ezekiel's tour of the river coming out of **the temple**
- **47:6-7** The trees on the side of the river
- **47:8-12** The river goes to the Dead Sea and brings new life

47:13-23

B - The Borders of the Restored Land Inheritance

A - **47:13-14** The land inheritance to be distributed to the 12 tribes of Israel

B - **47:15-20** Description of the land's 4 outer borders

A' - **47:21-23** The land inheritance to be distributed for the 12 tribes, including immigrants

48:1-29

B' - The Restored Land Inheritance for the Twelve Tribes

A - **48:1-7** The land inheritance of the 7 tribes north of the sacred reserve

B - **48:8-22** The central sacred reserve for the Levites, priests, temple, city, and chief

A' - **48:23-29** The land inheritance of the 5 tribes south of the sacred reserve

48:30-35

A' - The Twelve Gates of the City and its Name

- **48:30-35** The reserve-city's 12 gates for the 12 tribes, and the name of **the city**

Ezekiel 47:1-48:35. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).

Translation and Literary Design of Ezekiel 47:1-12

¹ And he brought me back to the door of the house;
and look, **waters** were coming out from under the threshold of the house **toward the east**,
for the house was **facing east**,
and the **waters** were going down down from underneath,
from the south side of the house,
from south of the altar.

² And he brought me out by way of the north gate,
and he led me around a way on the outside,
to the outside gate,
by way of the gate that **faces east**,
and look, **waters** were trickling from the south side.

³ When the man went out **toward the east**,
with a line in his hand,
then he measured a thousand cubits,
and he led me through the **waters**, **waters** reaching the ankles.

⁴ **And he measured a thousand**,
and led me through the **waters**, **waters** reaching the knees;
and he measured a thousand,
and led me through the **waters**, **waters** reaching the thighs,

⁵ **and he measured a thousand**,
and it was a **river** that I was not able to cross,
for the **waters** had risen,
waters for swimming in,
a **river** that could not be crossed.

⁶ And he said to me,
"Son of a human,
do you seen this?"

And he brought and returned me back **to the edge of the river**.

⁷ When he returned me, look, **at the edge of the river**,
trees, very many, on the one side and on the other.

8 And he said to me,
“These **waters** are going out **toward region of the east** ,
and going down into the southern-desert,
then they go toward the sea,
being made to flow into the sea,
and the **waters** of the sea **are healed** .

9 And it will come about, every living creature that swarms,
in every place where the **river** goes,
they will have life .
And there will be **fish, very many** ,
for where these **waters** go, then they **are healed** ,
and everywhere the **river** goes,
they will have life .

10 And it will come about that fishermen will stand beside it;
from the Spring of Gedi to the Spring of Eglayim,
there will be a place for the spreading of nets.
Their **fish** will be according to their kinds,
like **the fish of the Great Sea, very many** .

11 But its swamps and marshes,
they **will not be healed** ,
they will be left for salt.

12 **By the river on its edge,**
on one side and on the other ,
there will come up every kind of tree for food ;
their leaves will not wither,
and their fruit will not finish,
and each month they will bring first-fruit,
because their **waters** flow from the sanctuary,
and their fruit will be for food ,
and **their leaves for healing** .”

Ezekiel 47:1-12. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).

The Temple's River of Life

The river turns from a trickle in the temple (Ezek. 47:2) into a river a mile wide (Ezek. 47:6), turning the desert of the Dead Sea region into a fruitful land full of flowers and fish!

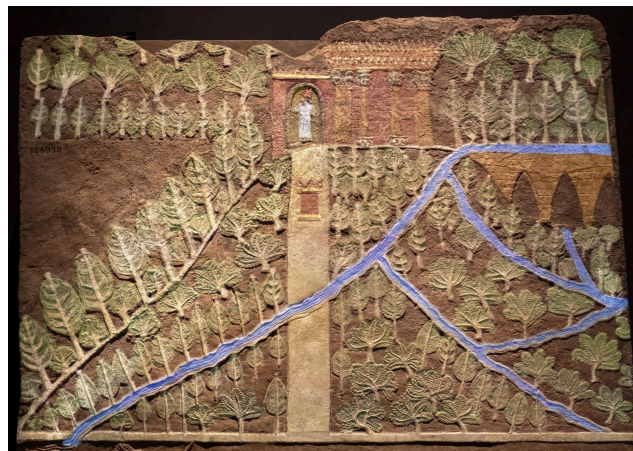
This motif is a common poetic image in the prophets of the new creation. It's rooted in the creation narrative of Genesis 1-2 where the chaotic, dark wilderness (Gen. 1:2) that is uninhabitable (Gen. 2:5-6) is transformed

into a lush garden (Gen. 1-2) that contains the head of a huge river that enriches the known world (Gen. 2:10-14).

The Zion psalms (Ps. 46-48, see also Ps. 36) depict the temple with this symbolic-poetic imagery to describe Yahweh as the source of all life.

Later prophets use these images (desert into garden) of future hope (Isa. 41:17-20, 44:1-5; Joel 3:17-18; Zech. 14:8-9), or they reverse the images (garden into desert) as an image of the day of Yahweh (Joel 2:3; Jer. 4:24-26).

This was a common motif in ancient Near Eastern conceptions of temples as a meeting place of Heaven and Earth and as sources of divine life that enrich the world with fertility. (Below: image of Ashurbanipal's royal garden with temple atop the hill, 7th century B.C.E.)



SPL. [National Geographic](#).

Ezekiel's vision is about the heavenly temple as the source of divine life that will flow out of Yahweh's presence and transform all creation. Even though he portrays this restoration only within the framework of Israel's promised land, this localized image is itself a picture of cosmic restoration. The Eden river (Gen. 2:10-14) was the source of life to the known kingdoms of the world (Egypt, Assyria, Babylon). It's this universal meaning that John the visionary adopts from Ezekiel in his depiction of the new Jerusalem in Revelation 21-22.

The New Allocation of the Land

In Ezekiel 47:13-48:29, Ezekiel depicts a new division and allotment of land according to boundaries and equal divisions that never existed historically before or after him. It is theological geography with symmetry designed to emphasize key themes.

The order and placement of the tribes reflects an ancestral grading system. The tribes from Jacob's concubines (Dan, Asher, Naphtali, Gad) are placed furthest from the sanctuary, while those descended from his two wives are placed equally on both sides of it. This results in a reordering of location that departs from any historical reality.

Ezekiel 47:13-14 emphasizes equality. The historical locations of the tribes were the result of many complicated factors and mixed motives of different tribes (Dan relocated to found a new temple, Judges 17-21; the Transjordan tribes had mixed motives, Num. 32; the Northern tribes seceded after Solomon, 1 Kgs. 11-12).

Ezekiel 45:8-9 emphasizes security. Ezekiel's vision ensures the land will forever remain a tribal possession; it will not be seized by the monarchy for abuse as it was so many times in Israel's history (e.g., Naboth's vineyard, 1 Kgs. 21).

Ezekiel 47:21-23 emphasizes the inclusion of the nations. Ezekiel surprisingly depicts gentiles and immigrants who take up permanent residence among Israel as eligible for possession of the ancestral lands. This is tantamount to full inclusion in the covenant people, as dramatic as Isaiah's statement in Isaiah 56:1-8.

The New Jerusalem and Its Gates

The naming of the gates of the new city in Ezekiel 48:30-35 had precedence earlier in Israel's history (2 Kgs. 14:13; Jer. 37:13), but Ezekiel's is a schematic representation of all of the tribes.

The city is a perfect square (Ezek. 48:30-35), as is the temple at its center, and in that center is the glorious presence of Yahweh that Ezekiel saw in Babylon at the beginning of the book (Ezek. 1:3). The book comes full circle, depicting the reunion of Heaven and Earth in the new creation with Jerusalem as the symbolic center of Yahweh's redemptive work.

The Name of the City

The name of the city in Ezekiel 48:35 is not, contrary to most contemporary translations, "Yahweh is there." That translation would require the Hebrew *Yahweh sham* (יהוה שם), and that is not what the Hebrew of Ezekiel 48:35 says! There is a modifying suffix on "there" called a directional *heh*, (an -ah attached to the end of a word) which directs attention away from the perspective of the speaker: *Yahweh shammah* (יהוה שמה).

- "the skies" (השמים), "toward the skies" (השמימה, see Gen. 15:5)
- "the house" (הבית), "toward/into the house" (הביתה, see Gen. 43:16)
- "there" (שם), "over there/to there" (שמה, see Gen. 19:20)

When the noun "there" (שם / *sham*) is used with the directional *heh*, it always means "over there" (שמה).

Ezekiel 1:20 NASB*

Wherever the Spirit was, the living-beings went toward there/over there (שמה) ...

Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Jeremiah 27:22 NASB*

They will be carried to Babylon and they will be over there (שמה) until the day I visit them ...

Key Words Adapted by Teacher

The point of all of this is that the name of the city is "Yahweh is over there," which points to the temple at the center of the land. In other words, Yahweh is not in the city, but "over there" in the temple. The city has become a symbolic pointer to the dwelling place of Yahweh in the temple. This is a huge departure from the

David-Zion traditions, where Zion is equivalent with the palace of the Davidic king and with the temple. Ezekiel's critique of the monarchy is connected to this total separation of the temple from the power of the monarchy. It is Yahweh's presence and authority alone that stand at the center of the land.

"When used in texts such as Genesis 19:20, 22; 21:13, and Jeremiah 18:2, the Hebrew *shammah* points to a place one anticipates visiting, a destination. The name of Ezekiel's city thus suggests it is the rendezvous point for those on their way to the divine presence. 'The Lord whom you see is that-a-way'—the city is a key waypoint or port of call for pilgrims seeking to draw near to God."

Cook, Stephen L. (2018). [*Ezekiel 38-48: A New Translation with Introduction and Commentary*](#). Yale University Press. 297.

Appendix: Crucial Factors in Interpreting Ezekiel's Temple Vision

Historical Context

The vision is the final dated oracle in the book of Ezekiel (see [48:35](#), 40:1). It is dated to first day of a new year, 25 years after Jehoiachin's deportation (597 B.C.E.), 14 years after the destruction of Jerusalem (586 B.C.E.), and 10 years after his salvation oracles began (as noted in [48:35](#), 33:21-22), that is, in the year 572 B.C.E.

However interpreters integrate Ezekiel's vision into their larger synthesis of biblical eschatology, we must take this primary context seriously. This vision is first and foremost a message from Ezekiel to his contemporaries in exile, and part of the Hebrew Bible's message to post-exilic Israel back in Jerusalem.

Twenty-five years is half of a Jubilee cycle (referred to in [Ezek. 48:35](#); 46:17), and the 10th day of the first month is precisely the day that the preparations for Passover begin (see [Ezek. 48:35](#); Exod. 12:3). Both Passover and the Jubilee are deeply connected to the story of Yahweh's liberation of his people and his land from slavery (see [Ezek. 48:35](#); Exod. 12-13; Lev. 25).

Literary Genre

This final vision is called "visions of *Elohim*" (*מראות אלהים*, [Ezek. 40:2](#)). This is the same title given to his earlier visions of the divine throne-chariot ([Ezek. 1:1-3](#)) and of his virtual tour of the Jerusalem temple ([8:1](#)). Those visions are explicitly placed "in-between the skies and the land" ([Ezek. 8:3](#)), which is a biblical way of referring to what we would call an "alternate dimension" of reality, which explains the many symbolic and surreal features of his visionary experiences.

- He devours an entire scroll written with divine words ([Ezek. 2:8-3:3](#)).
- He was seized by his hair and transported to Jerusalem ([Ezek. 8:3](#)).
- He digs through walls and enters secret rooms of the temple ([Ezek. 8:8](#)).
- He sees multiple scenes of Israelite idolatrous worship happening simultaneously, even though they actually happened over the course of many years. Manasseh's Asherah statue of [Ezekiel 8:5](#) was already torn down by Josiah in the time before Ezekiel, yet he sees it as present in the moment. The Tammuz

rituals are also described by Jeremiah (Jer. 7:18), but happened decades after the time of Manasseh and Josiah.

- He sees angelic messengers of destruction touring about the city marking some people's foreheads and destroying others. This event is a symbolic depiction of the remnant who is spared from the Babylonian onslaught, while others will be killed in the siege and attack on the city (see Ezek. 9). Ezekiel also sees divine fire from the throne chariot thrown down upon the city.
- Ezekiel "sees" the divine glory leave the temple and Jerusalem and cross the valley of Kidron and go over the Mount of Olives (Ezek. 11:22-25).

Ezekiel's "divine visions" are apocalyptic experiences in which he gains access to the heavens where he "sees" a world of symbols that give him new perspective on earthly events. These visions are packed with heavy doses of symbolism steeped in earlier biblical imagery (cosmic creation, Eden, Sinai, Jerusalem, and temple). Whatever interpretive principles we use to understand the symbolism of Ezekiel 1 and 8-11, it is only consistent that we approach Ezekiel 40-48 with the same expectations.

Biblical Theme

Ezekiel's temple vision is the culmination of a core biblical theme that began in Genesis 1-2 and is developed throughout the Hebrew Bible.

1. The Cosmic Temple

Genesis 1:1-2:3 depicts creation as the separation and organization of a three-tiered cosmos (the skies, the land, the abyss under the land) in which Heaven and Earth are joined together through the image of God—humanity as God's royal-priests.

The seven-day scheme and the sequence from chaos to cosmos, the placement of the divine image on the land, these details (and many more) portray creation as a cosmic temple.

2. Eden as Proto-Temple

Eden is portrayed as a high mountain garden where Heaven and Earth overlap, and the place to which God elevates humanity to learn wisdom and the fear of the Lord so they can rule the world as God's partners.

Genesis 1-2 depict a divine ideal for the cosmos as a place where Heaven and Earth are distinct realms that overlap and are bound together in harmony.

3. The Promised Land, Mount Moriah, and Bethel

The land of Canaan is depicted as an Eden-like land, to which Abraham is elevated out of the "fire of the Chaldeans" (Gen. 11:27-32). It is a place where he meets with God on high mountains and by sacred trees, and is blessed by God (Gen. 12:1-9, 13:12-18).

Because of Abraham and Sarah's sin against Hagar (Gen. 16), God requires the surrender of Abraham's firstborn sons (Ishmael in Gen. 21 and Isaac in Gen. 22). On Mount Moriah (proto-Zion) God provides a substitute offering that both redeems the chosen son and dies for the sins of Abraham and Sarah.

God meets Jacob at Bethel ([Gen. 28:10-20](#)), where he has an apocalyptic vision of Heaven and Earth overlapping in a field. He sees the ramp that connects Heaven and Earth, and he receives a promise that God will restore him to this Eden-like land after his long exile. Note that Jacob encounters angelic boundary-guards when he re-enters the land ([Gen. 32:1-2](#)).

4. Mount Sinai

In the burning bush ([Exod. 3](#)), on Mount Horeb/Sinai, Moses encounters a divine-human figure in the middle of a fiery tree, and the space is called “holy ground.” This will become the same place where Israel will come to meet with Yahweh ([Exod. 19](#)) who will appear in cloud, wind, and fire ([Exod. 19-20](#)).

- 5. The tabernacle
- 6. The Jordan River
- 7. Jerusalem, Zion, the temple

Ezekiel and the Exodus Narrative

The structure of much of this vision seems to intentionally recall the broad narrative structure of the Exodus and Sinai narratives. [Adapted from Block, Daniel (2013). “Envisioning the Good News: Ten Interpretive Keys to Ezekiel’s Final Vision.” In [Beyond the River Chebar: Studies in Kingship and Eschatology in the Book of Ezekiel](#) (1st ed., pp. 175-196). The Lutterworth Press. 163-164.]

Feature	Exodus Narrative	Ezekiel’s Restoration Oracles
Yahweh commissions a human agent.	Exod. 3–4	Ezek. 33
Yahweh separates Israel from the nations and delivers her from bondage.	Exod. 5–13	Ezek. 34–37
Enemy forces challenge Yahweh’s salvific work on his people’s behalf.	Exod. 14–15	Ezek. 38–39
Yahweh appears on a high mountain.	Exod. 19	Ezek. 40:1–4
Yahweh provides for his residence among his people.	Exod. 25–40	Ezek. 40:5–43:27
Yahweh prescribes the appropriate response to his grace.	Leviticus	Ezek. 44:1–46:24
Yahweh provides for the apportionment of his land to his	Num. 34–35	Ezek. 47–48

Ezekiel Mirrors Exodus. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).

Feature	Exodus Narrative	Ezekiel's Restoration Oracles
people.		
<i>Ezekiel Mirrors Exodus.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).		

The Relationship Between Ezekiel's Torah and Moses' Torah

There are similarities between the divine revelations Ezekiel and Moses receive. They are both received on high mountains to be given to the people after the making of a covenant, both focus on temple and priestly concerns with Levites and an elite family of priests, the presence of Yahweh is manifest in divine cloud, and neither Ezekiel nor Moses get to personally experience the promised land.

There are also differences. The priestly line is different (Zadok vs. Aaron [Ezek. 43:19](#), [Ezek. 44:15](#)), the priestly garments are different ([44:17-19](#)); there are no temple furnishings; and there are different offerings (e.g., New Moon in [46:6-7](#) vs. [Num. 28:11](#)).

Earlier References

These are not the only places Ezekiel pointed forward to Israel's new worship temple. He developed this theme in [Ezekiel 20:32-45](#) and [Ezekiel 37:26-28](#) and the images from those texts need to be taken into account here.

Symbolic and Stylized Elements in the Vision

Some elements in Ezekiel's vision stretch the imagination or represent a clearly symbolic ideal.

1. The "high mountain" ([Ezek. 40:2](#), never named as Jerusalem) where the temple is located is a clear "Eden," "Zion," and "Sinai" motif. The fact that all of these distinct sacred mountain spaces can be merged together into one geographical place means that we are dealing with a transcendent "space" where Heaven and Earth overlap. (Jerusalem sits on a ridge 2,500 feet above sea level and is overshadowed by the Mount of Olives to the east; these are clearly poetic descriptions; Zaphon in [Ps. 48:2](#) was the Canaanite version of the Greek Mount Olympus, see also [Isa. 2:2](#) and [Mic. 4:1](#)).
2. The river flowing out of the temple ([Ezek. 47](#)) was never a reality ([Ps. 46:4](#); [Joel 3:18](#); [Zech. 14:8](#)).
3. The structure is highly symbolic. This was true of the tabernacle and temple as well, but in this structure even more so.

"The plan of the city is idealized as a perfect square with three gates punctuating each side to provide admittance for the twelve tribes. The emphasis on the twelve tribes itself reverses five centuries of history. The apportionment of the land of Israel among the tribes to a large extent disregards topographic and historical realities. The dimensions of the temple and the city are dominated by multiples of five, with

twenty-five being a particularly common number. All in all Ezekiel's scheme appears highly contrived, casting doubt on any interpretation that expects a literal fulfillment of his plan."

Block, Daniel (1998). [*The Book of Ezekiel, Chapters 25-48 \(The New International Commentary on the Old Testament\)*](#). Eerdmans.

Reception of This Vision in Judaism and Christianity

Ezekiel's plan was apparently not read or received as a literal program of restoration by anyone in the post-exilic community (Ezra-Nehemiah shows a desire to restore Israel according to the Mosaic Torah, not Ezekiel's: no land redivision, no "prince," the temple was not built according to Ezekiel's description).

When John the visionary depicts the new creation in [Revelation 21-22](#), he is clearly adopting language and imagery from Ezekiel 40-48 (John's vision is on a "high mountain" in 21:10; a new Jerusalem in which God dwells in 21:11; the heavenly guide with a measuring rod in 21:15-17; symmetrical plan for the city in 21:11-21; river of life in 22:1), but never literally. He adapts Ezekiel's images for his own rhetorical and theological purposes.

- John names the city as the new Jerusalem ([Rev. 21:2](#)) where Ezekiel leaves it unnamed to separate it from its past ([40:2](#)), and later renames it "Yahweh is there" ([48:35](#)).
- John's city emphatically has no temple ([Rev. 21:22](#)), which is a theological impossibility for Ezekiel, where it's at the center of the land.
- Sacrifices: Ezekiel portrays a fully functioning sacrificial system run by Zadokite priestly staff. In Revelation this would be a theological contradiction as the lamb has already been slain ([Rev. 21:22](#)).
- City residents: In John, believers are purified by the sacrifice of the Lamb of God ([Rev. 7:14](#)), while in Ezekiel there is continued need to distinguish pure from impure.
- The nations: In Ezekiel, there is a purely ethnic-Israelite focus, but in Revelation the scope of the renewal is for all nations (cross reference the leaves of the tree in [Ezek. 47:12](#) and [Rev. 22:2](#)).

Ezekiel's Other Visions

Ezekiel contains numerous visionary experiences that were clearly symbolic explorations of theological realities.

- Eating the scroll in [2:1-3:15](#) symbolizes accepting the message of judgment and internalizing its reality as mediator.
- Consider the symbolism of throwing fire on Jerusalem and the symbolic "slaughter" in [Ezekiel 9:1-11](#).
- Re-creating the dry bones into new humans in [Ezekiel 37](#) is a promise of national covenant renewal.
- Ezekiel 40-48 is a similar visionary exploration of the meaning and hope of Yahweh's return to his people and what kinds of realities will exist when God dwells among his people.

Main Interpretive Views of Ezekiel's Temple

A Blueprint for the Eschaton

This view holds that Ezekiel's temple vision describes an actual temple to be built when the Messiah returns to restore Jerusalem and rebuild the messianic kingdom.

There are several problems with this view.

- There is no basis in the New Testament for the hope of a restored temple in Jerusalem. Any texts that might be appealed to are fraught with interpretive challenges and are by no means a clear anticipation of a new temple that should be associated with Christian hope.
- In the depiction of the new creation in Revelation 21:22, it is very clear that there is no centralized temple because the entire creation is filled with God's presence.
- The gospels portray Jesus as the ultimate reality to which the physical temple pointed (John 2:13-22). Jesus acted and spoke as if he played the role of the temple (offering forgiveness, Mark 2:1-13; healing and purifying the unclean, Mark 5:24-34; receiving worship, Matt. 14:33).
- The rest of the New Testament portrays "the body of Christ," i.e., the community of Jesus' followers, as the body of the Messiah, that is, as a temple (John 7:37-39; Acts 2:1-4; 1 Cor. 3:16-17; 1 Pet. 2:4-10).
- The restored temple in Ezekiel 40-48 presumes an Israel that still sins and requires sacrifices of atonement for their sins. This stands in tension with a vision of the restored Israel as fully obedient to God's will (Ezek. 36:22-36) and also with the idea that Jesus' death and resurrection provided an ultimate and unrepeatable act of cosmic atonement (as in Heb. 8-10).

A Symbolic Ideal

This view holds that these chapters are part of Ezekiel's prophetic message of challenge and hope (Ezek. 40:4, 43:10-12) aimed at generating repentance. He depicts an idealized temple using "symbolic geography and architecture" to convey his prophetic message; it was not intended for precise historical reference or as a blueprint for those attempting to build a future temple.

The location of the temple ("a very high mountain", Ezek. 40:2) is symbolic. "High mountain" = symbolic connection point between Heaven and Earth. The temple is heavenly and already exists, and it doesn't need to be built.

The city-temple complex is over one mile wide and a perfect square, a magnified version of the holy of holies (Ezek. 48:17, 48:35).

There is a river coming from the temple mount (Ezek. 47:1-12). It is a symbolic stream that plays a similar role to the four-headed river from Eden (Gen. 2:10-14).

The image of priests offering continuing sacrifices (Ezek. 45) and of the messianic "prince" having sin offerings made on his behalf (Ezek. 45:22) is inconsistent with the New Testament theology of the finality of Christ's sacrificial death (Heb. 9-10).

Territorial Rhetoric (Utopian Vision)

At multiple points in the visions, Ezekiel is told the purpose of his being shown these spaces and what he is supposed to do with all that he sees and writes down.

Ezekiel 40:1-4 and 43:1-11 make it clear that Ezekiel's vision was originally addressed to an exilic audience, and it was designed to have a rhetorical impact on their view of the hoped for restoration and on their view of

themselves before Yahweh.

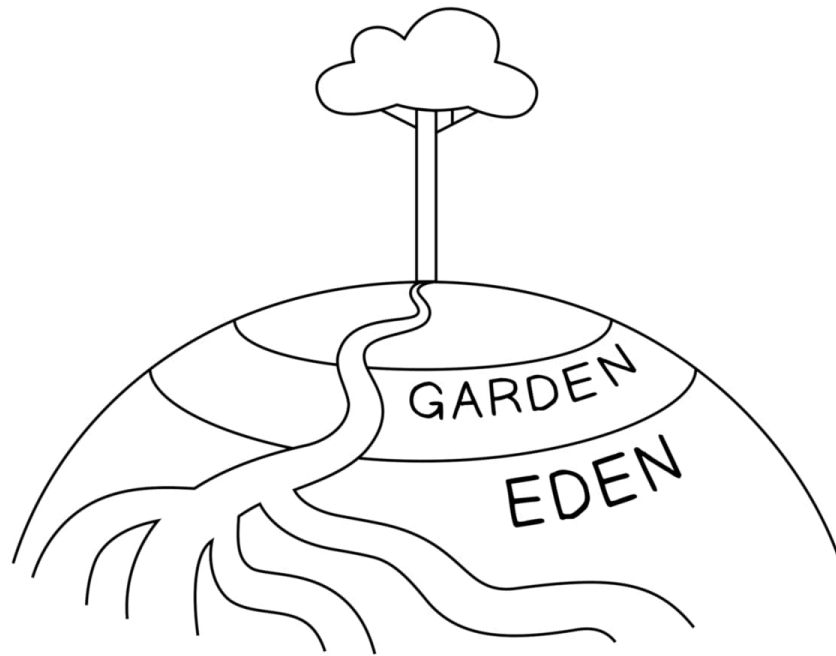
"If Ezekiel 40-48 do not provide a construction blueprint for the post-exilic temple, is this temple intended to be only a literary creation, a symbol for the universal presence of God? ... What would be the rhetorical purpose of producing a text in the Babylonian exile which organizes post-exilic Israel around a temple if Ezekiel didn't expect the returned Israel to have a temple? I find it incomprehensible that Ezekiel could imagine a society without a temple at the symbolic center of the society. Rather than a choice between a building plan or a symbolic metaphor, there is a third option: it is territorial rhetoric ... This text calls for radical social change, by reorganizing Israel's entire geography around Yahweh's presence. Every space that was distorted and abused by Israel's priests and kings has been reshaped and made subordinate to Yahweh's presence in the land."

Stevenson, Kalinda Rose (1996). [*The Vision of Transformation: The Territorial Rhetoric of Ezekiel 40-48*](#). Scholars Press. 151-153.

"Sir Thomas More in 1516 invented the term 'utopia' by playing on two Greek prefixes, *ou* and *eu*. The prefix *ou* means 'no/not' and *eu* means 'good/well.' Combined with the Greek word *topos*, which means 'place' a utopia is thus, at once a place of well-being and a fictive non-place. What More's utopia is not, contrary to widespread usage, is a perfect place. And neither is Ezekiel's ideal temple and land. Ezekiel's utopia is not yet the full realization of God's reign over the new creation. Access to the temple is still limited to only the priests, sacrifices of atonement for sins are still necessary, and the ideal David of Ezekiel 34:23-24 and 37:25 is a far cry from the diminished "chief" of Ezekiel 40-48. In particular, Israel's promised future heart transplant is not presupposed (Ezek. 11:19-20 and 36:26-27); atonement offerings would not be necessary if it had already taken place. A literary utopia of More's type is a means of social critique, which must grapple persuasively with the continuing struggles and tragedies of real life. A literary utopia thus keeps at least one foot in the problematic world of the present ... The original island of Utopia described by More in his book of 1516 was not futuristic or eschatological, but an engaging critique of contemporary England. Similarly, Ezekiel 40-48 is not a vision of a future God-given reality, which readers must fit into all of God's other plans for earth's destiny. Neither is it a blueprint for an actual, realistic temple slated for human construction ... It is a revolutionary text designed to challenge the status quo as Israel looked forward to its return from Babylon."

Cook, Stephen L. (2018). [*Ezekiel 38-48: A New Translation with Introduction and Commentary*](#). Yale University Press. 5-6.

The River from the Garden of Eden



GEN 2

The River from the Garden of Eden. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).

Reflection Question

How do you make sense of all the different images of rivers, cities, trees, temples, and mountains layered in visions like Ezekiel 40-48?

Session 29: Reflecting on Ezekiel

Key Takeaways

- Prophetic literature is some of the most challenging to interpret and requires wisdom to engage it well. But it provides a lifetime's worth of meditation and reflection.
- Ezekiel demonstrates a faithful response to God's calling. He lives out a parable of God's message to his people, trusting that God would bring about everything he said he would.
- The book of Ezekiel invites us to walk about the story of Israel with God and to consider the height, width, and breadth of God's love and faithfulness in bringing his people through exile into new life in his presence.



This session has no notes

Reflection Question

Take some time to reflect on the insights you learned in this class.